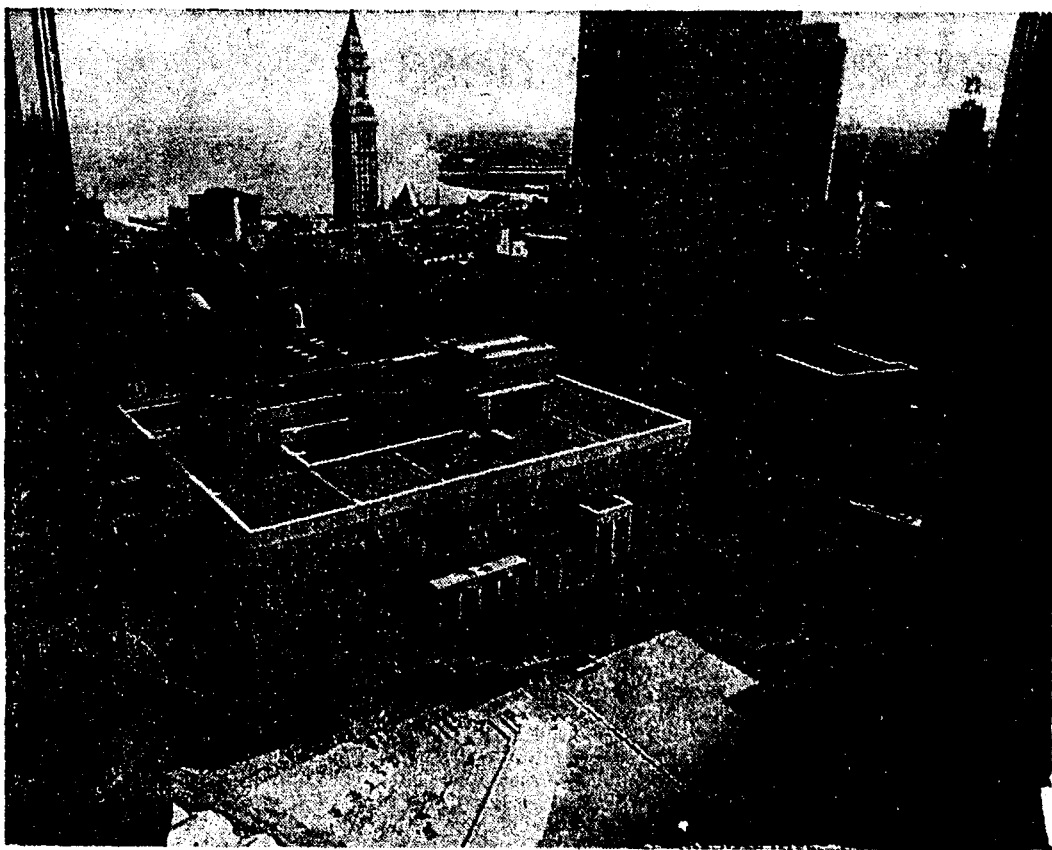




CITY HALL PLAZA . . . LIKE A PARKING LOT TEMPORARILY CLEARED OF CARS.

The trouble at City Hall Plaza

Why is it that, in spite of the best efforts of Summerthing, City Hall Plaza never seems to come to life or be the right size for any activity smaller than a Bund rally?

It's always too big, too empty, too grand. There are too many things it doesn't have enough of. For example:

- Enormous sidewalk cafes, with parasols over the tables;
- Shouting street vendors selling eggplants and knishes;
- Men playing flutes, with small crowds listening;
- People making speeches about how the Communists are stealing our bodily fluids;
- Moonlight concerts on hot nights;

In other words, life.

American tourists flock to a place like the Piazza San Marco in Venice.

Not to admire the architecture, but just to sit at a cafe, sip a soft drink or wine and watch people walk by, looking like actors strolling on a stage.

But City Hall Plaza doesn't look or feel like a stage. It looks more like a parking lot temporarily cleared of cars. It doesn't have a real cafe, and if it did, you wouldn't sit there because there wouldn't be anyone to watch, and even if there were, they wouldn't look as if they were on a stage. They would look as if they were trying to get across the Gobi desert ahead of the bandits.

In case anyone doesn't know, the reason nobody is out there selling

ARCHITECTURE / By ROBERT CAMPBELL

tacos in the plaza is because the city forbids it. The city believes that the plaza is there in order to give each of us a perfect, uncluttered view of City Hall.

If you can think of better things to do with it, you might try writing the Mayor.

Last Sunday, The Globe carried an unobtrusive article on page 35, which said the Federal government will probably give back to Massachusetts all the money that was earmarked for the Inner Belt and the other highways that have been killed by citizen revolts in recent years. The total, close to a billion dollars over the next decade, could be used for rapid transit.

The story brought to mind the first meetings in Cambridge around 1966, when a few people began to get together to try to do something about the Inner Belt, then planned as an eight-lane swathe through the center of the city. The priest of a church on Pearl Street in Cambridgeport held meetings in his parish house. Six or eight people would show up and talk, pretty despairingly, about what they could do. A volunteer young architect and planner helped design an alternate, less destructive route for the Belt along the railroad right-of-way near MIT.

That was the best anybody dared hope for; in those days, no one thought you could stop superhighways in their tracks — they were Progress.

MIT didn't like the alternate route, so it issued a press release that made the headlines of all the Boston papers. The press release said that delicate research vital to the national security was going on at MIT and that the alternate Inner Belt route, which would have taken a couple of minor MIT buildings, would damage this research. Therefore the people who didn't like the Inner Belt were endangering national security.

After a while, the tide began to turn. Harvard Design School held a debate, Sen. Kennedy asked for a review of the Inner Belt in Washington, and slowly, amazingly, the whole city-destroying monster began to come apart before everyone's eyes.

Now we learn that the people who met in the Parish House, and all those like them, did more than kill the Inner Belt.

They gave us a billion dollars. A fitting use for some of it, as a start, would be to demolish the city's ugliest aerial junkyard, the Fitzgerald Expressway, and put it underground.